Who pays for the rider? The math behind Swish Go's Rs 0 fee

Mohammad Faiz Ahmad · IIT Patna · October 2026 · built only from public filings and press

> **My read:** Swish can easily afford Rs 0 fees today, but keeping them is a different matter. On Swish-sized baskets (Rs 200–250), a Go order needs roughly **17–26% commission just to pay for its own delivery**. That's the same band Bengaluru restaurants were threatening to boycott in August. Go works as a model only if its orders ride on the density Swish has already built around its own kitchens. Otherwise it's a launch discount.

Three ways to pay for one delivery

Model	Customer pays	Restaurant pays	What the platform keeps
Swiggy / Zomato	Platform fee Rs 17.58 + delivery and packaging	8–28% commission, plus ads	Revenue 26.0% of GOV (Swiggy), 32.8% of NOV (Eternal). Contribution after per-order costs: 7.6% and 10.2%
Rapido Ownly	Flat Rs 30 delivery fee	Nothing	About Rs 30 an order. 50,000+ orders a day in Bengaluru (Aug 2026)
Swish Go	Rs 0 platform and packaging fee	Not disclosed	Whatever commission it charges, and nothing else

The line that matters is the first one. Even charging both sides, the two leaders keep only 7.6 to 10.2 paise of each rupee of orders after per-order costs. The other ~18–23% of order value goes on delivery, discounts and payments. Go gives up the customer side entirely, and the platform fee alone is 7.8% of a Rs 225 basket.

What commission does a Rs 0 fee order need?

To cover its own variable cost: **commission = rider cost ÷ basket + 1.5% payments + 2% refunds and support**.

Basket	Rider Rs 30	Rider Rs 40	Rider Rs 50
Rs 200	18.5%	23.5%	28.5%
Rs 225 (Swish's own basket, midpoint)	16.8%	21.3%	25.7%
Rs 300	13.5%	16.8%	20.2%
Rs 400	11.0%	13.5%	16.0%

The rider cost is my assumption. Rapido, which runs a rider network, prices a delivery at Rs 30, so I treat that as close to the floor. The payment and refund shares are also my assumptions. Marketing, tech and kitchens are left out, so this is a floor, not a profit number.

Two things stand out. Basket size moves the answer more than anything Swish can negotiate: going from Rs 225 to Rs 400 cuts the break-even commission from 21% to 13.5% at a Rs 40 rider. And every Rs 10 off the rider cost is worth about 4.4 points of commission on a Rs 225 basket.

Can Swish afford it? Yes, for now

Say Go charges a restaurant-friendly 15% with a Rs 40 rider. It loses about **Rs 14 per order**. Even if Go matched Swish's entire current volume (1M+ orders a month), that's about Rs 1.4 crore a month. That's roughly 7.5% a year of the Rs 224.5 crore Swish raised in September. So runway isn't the constraint. The constraint is that a price of zero is hard to raise later, and the loss grows with every order Go wins.

There's also a less obvious comparison. At 15%, Go collects about Rs 34 an order, which is roughly what Ownly collects (Rs 30). **The two charge about the same for a delivery. They just send the bill to different people.** Ownly bills the customer. Go bills the restaurant, at a moment when restaurants are openly fighting commissions.

What I'd do

1. **Grow the basket, not the fee.** Keep Rs 0 above a basket threshold and add a small-cart fee below it. Pair that with combos from Go restaurants. The table above says basket size is the cheapest lever.
2. **Put Go orders on the kitchen network's riders.** Inc42 reports that Go doesn't promise Swish's 15-minute fulfilment, which leaves room to batch Go pickups with own-kitchen runs inside the same 1–2 km cluster. This is the one cost advantage Ownly and Swiggy can't copy quickly.
3. **Pitch restaurants on certainty, not just the rate.** In August, Swiggy agreed to refund charges restaurants said were levied without consent. A flat, published Go rate with no ad or visibility add-ons answers that complaint directly, even if the rate itself is in the high teens.

The one number I'd watch

Rider cost per Go order, tracked by pincode. If batching brings it toward Rs 30 and baskets reach Rs 300, Go breaks even at around 14% commission and the Rs 0 fee can stay. If it sits at Rs 50 on Rs 225 baskets, Go needs about 26%, and the Rs 0 fee has an end date. Next to it I'd track how many Go orders are new rather than moved over from Swish's own kitchens. A moved order earns a commission instead of the full food margin.

Caveats

Go's own basket size and commission are not public, so I use Swish's own-kitchen basket (Rs 200–250, Mar 2026). Go's restaurants may run bigger baskets, which would help Go. Swiggy reports on GOV, which includes fees and taxes. Eternal now reports on NOV, which is net of discounts. So their percentages are not like for like, and I only use them as a range. Restaurant-side terms for Ownly have varied between reports. Q2 FY27 results were not out when I wrote this. Every input, with its source, is in sources.md. Live model (change any assumption): faizafham.github.io/rider-economics/

Sources: Swiggy Q1 FY27 letter to shareholders (NSE, 30 Jul 2026); Eternal Q1 FY27 shareholder letter; Storyboard18 on platform fees (Mar 2026); MediaNama on Ownly (Mar 2026); Angel One on Ownly volumes (Aug 2026); Inc42 on Swish Go (7 Oct 2026), Swish's Sep 2026 raise and the Swiggy refund (7 Aug 2026); Restaurant India on Swish's raise and FY25 (Sep 2026); The Week on the BBHA boycott (30 Jul 2026).